

Freshman Alumni Bot

A guide for group leaders · @freshmanalumni_bot

How to set it up

Three steps, about a minute.

- 1 Open the group you want the bot working in, and add it as a member: **Members** → **Add member** → @freshmanalumni_bot
- 2 Promote it to **Administrator**, and turn on the **Pin messages** right.
- 3 Send **/gate_announce** in the group. The bot posts and pins the join announcement — and that command is also what switches the group on.

First time only: get yourself on the admin list.

Send **/id** to @freshmanalumni_bot in a private chat and give the number it replies with to **@gapyearingdoesntsuck**. This happens once, not per group — after that every group you set up is entirely self-service.

Step 3 needs it because switching a group on is what makes being a member there count towards joining the Alumni group. If just anyone could do it, they could make a group and let themselves in. Until you're on the list, **/gate_announce** stays silent rather than refusing.

Repeat all three in every group you want covered. Each one is switched on separately and gets its own announcement, so you choose which groups take part and you can add more whenever you like.

Reference

Read once, or only when something looks wrong.

Why Administrator matters

Admin rights are not a formality — the bot is inert without them. Telegram only tells a bot who joins a group if it is an administrator, and pinning needs the **Pin messages** right specifically. If you add the bot as an ordinary member, nothing happens at all: no enrolment, no announcement, no error. **That is the single most common reason a group looks broken.**

Promoting the bot also tells it the group exists — but on its own that grants nothing, because anyone can promote a bot in a group they just made. Step 3 is the part that counts, and it's why that command is restricted to people we've added to the admin list.

What the bot puts in your group

Exactly two things ever appear in the group chat:

- 1 **The pinned announcement** — two buttons, *Join the Alumni group* and *I'm already in it*. It re-posts itself every five days and deletes the previous one, so only one is ever live.
- 2 **A follow-up message** naming the people who still haven't tapped either button, sent a few days after the announcement.

Everything else is a private DM. Nobody is tagged in the group for not having joined, and nobody is corrected in front of everyone. You can tell your members that safely.

What a member goes through

So you can answer “what is this bot?” without asking us: they tap **Join the Alumni group**, which opens the bot in a private chat. There it asks them to fill in a short form, read the values doc, and send a 50–100 word intro. Once all three are done it hands them a personal one-time invite link and they're admitted automatically. Tapping **I'm already in it** is checked against the real group, so it can't be used to skip the process.

If something looks wrong

/gate_announce does nothing	Usually you're not on the admin list yet — see the box on page 1; it stays silent rather than refusing. Otherwise the bot is a member but not an Administrator , and can't post or read the group without that.
Nothing happened at all	Step 3 hasn't been done. Adding and promoting the bot alone leaves the group switched off — that's deliberate, not a fault.
It isn't pinned	The bot has admin rights but not Pin messages . The announcement still works unpinned.
“But I am in the group!”	Almost always a second Telegram account. Ask which account they use in the alumni group, and have them open the bot from that one.
“The bot won't reply to me”	They need to tap Start in the private chat once. Telegram won't let a bot message anyone who hasn't.
Anything else	Message @gapyearingdoesntsuck.

Someone who isn't in any of our groups

A guest speaker, or a graduate who left every chat years ago, can't be found by the checks above. Send **/gate_token** to the bot in a private chat, with a note about who it's for — it replies with a one-off code like FA-K7M2Q-XR94T. Pass that to the person; they paste it to the bot and go through the same onboarding, skipping the group check. The code works once and expires after 30 days. The bot only stores a fingerprint of it, so that reply is the only copy — if you lose it, issue another. **/gate_tokens** lists what you've handed out and **/gate_revoke** cancels an unused one.

Once you're on the admin list you also have **/gate_stats** (how many are in, mid-onboarding, or unengaged), **/gate_groups** (every group switched on) and **/gate_unwatch** (switch a group back off) — all in a private chat with the bot. Every one of them answers you privately, even when typed in a group.